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Libraries: Gift suggestions from library staff



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The holidays are here again so this week we thought we'd offer a list of staff suggestions for good books to give as gifts this year.

To start off with, I'm going to suggest Lydia Netzer's "How to Tell Toledo from the Night Sky." This book tells the story of George and Irene, two astronomers working for the Toledo Institute of Astronomy, who were born to be together - literally. Their mothers, when they were in junior high school, came up with a plan to separately have a boy and a girl and then raise them to eventually fall in love and get married. A friend of mine recommended it to me because she knew I like "Big Bang Theory" and this book is also about nerdy science-type people, but there is a lot more going on. It is one of the funniest books I have read in years.

Naomi, one of our shelveers, suggests "The Iron Trial" by Holly Black and Cassandra Clare, the first book in the "Magisterium Series." Naomi says that both children and adults alike will delight in this book because of its relatable characters and magical scenery. It has a delightful mix of elements from popular series such as "The Ranger's Apprentice" and "Harry Potter."

Debbie, our gardening expert, suggests "Quarter-acre Farm" by Spring Warren. Debbie says that it's a fine book to get as a gift for someone you know who is eager to be guided through the process of transitioning their property into a purposeful, sustainable food-producing environment. The book is informative and humorous as the author walks the reader through her learning experiences and contains some simple recipes she developed using the foods she grew and harvested.

In a similar vein, if you want to get a gift for a foodie or anyone who wants to know a little bit more about cooking, roasting, fermenting and barbecue, Connie, our courier, suggests "Cooked" by Michael Pollan. Pollan writes about how we take growing things and change their dynamic from raw to delectable.

And as a final book choice, Sally, one of our circulation desk staff members, suggests a book by Wendell Pierce. Yes, that Wendell Pierce - Bunk from HBO's "The Wire." The title is "The Wind in the Reeds" and Sally says that it is a lovely memoir that fleshes out the African-American experience. Pierce is the great grandson of slaves, and his account of the resilience of his people, especially

following Katrina is inspiring. Family, work and faith are all in evidence.

The last thing I'm going to suggest as a gift is not a book, but rather an e-reader - the Kindle Fire 7. At the library we've been getting a lot more experience with e-readers and we subscribe to two services made primarily for e-readers - Flipster and Overdrive. I have used e-readers as varied as the Pocket PC, the Aluratek, various Android tablets, iPads, Nooks and Kindles. All of these devices have their advantages and disadvantages but the one thing that they have all had in common is that, until very recently, the cheapest prices for quality new devices have been more than \$100. The new Kindle Fire 7, however, is a full blown, high quality e-reader/tablet at only \$49.99. In the past I have told a lot of people that if you're buying a tablet and you're paying less than \$150, you can expect short battery life, problems accessing a decent app store and a cheaply made plastic case and screen. Not with the new Kindle Fire 7. It is an excellent e-reader/tablet for its price.

In any event, all of us at the Latah County Library District hope that everyone has a great holiday season. And remember, if you don't get the book you want for Christmas, you can probably find it at the library.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

STORY TAGS

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